coursera | MoMA

Seeing Through Photographs ✕

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Module 4
One and Another

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 4
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Sarah Meister on Photography and Multiplicity
  Video • 2 min

Part II: Albums and Books
- ✓ Artwork Spotlight: Frances Benjamin Johnston's The Hampton Album, 1899-1900
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Frances Benjamin Johnston. The Hampton Album. 1899-1900
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Photo Books
  Reading • 8 min

Part III: Bodies of Work
- ✓ Photo Series
  Reading • 13 min
- ✓ Hear More: Nicholas Nixon on The Brown Sisters, 1975–2022
  Video • 1 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sohrab Hura on Snow, 2015–ongoing
  Video • 5 min

Part IV: One from Many
- ✓ One from Many
  Reading • 8 min
- ✓ Hear More: Irina Rozovsky on Miracle Center, 2019–ongoing
  Video • 5 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ✓ Practice Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 80%
- ✓ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Optional Readings and Resources
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Optional Mid-Course Survey
  Reading • 5 min

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 5
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Artwork Spotlight: Hank Willis Thomas's UNBRANDED series
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Hank Willis Thomas on the Role of Advertising Images
  Video • 3 min

Part II: Re-envisioning History
- ✓ Constructing History
  Reading • 4 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ Challenging History
  Reading • 6 min
- ○ Hear More: Carrie Mae Weems on From Here I Saw What Happened and I Cried, 1995–96
  Video • 2 min
- ○ Hear More: Walid Raad of The Atlas Group on My neck is thinner than a hair: Engines, 1996–2001
  Video • 1 min
- ○ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ Hear More: Harrell Fletcher on The American War, 2005
  Video • 4 min

Part III: Envisioning Selves and Stereotypes
- ○ Constructing Personal Narratives
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Hear More: Iñaki Bonillas on Constructing Identities
  Video • 5 min
- ○ Hear More: Eva Respini on Cindy Sherman. Untitled Film Stills. 1977–80
  Video • 1 min
- ○ Hear More: David Alekhuogie on To Live and Die in LA, 2019
  Video • 4 min

Part IV: Review and Respond
- ○ Practice Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • 30 min
- ○ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Optional Readings and Resources
  Reading • 10 min

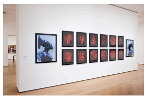
Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

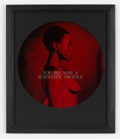
Challenging History

0:31 / 5:10 1x

Carrie Mae Weems



Carrie Mae Weems. *From Here I Saw What Happened and I Cried*. 1995–96. Fourteen of 33 chromogenic color prints with sandblasted text on glass, each 26 3/4 × 22" (67.9 × 55.8 cm) or 43 1/2 × 33 1/2" (110.4 × 85 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift on behalf of The Friends of Education of The Museum of Modern Art. Installation view, *Pictures by Women: A History of Modern Photography*, The Museum of Modern Art, New York, May 7, 2010–April 18, 2011. Photo: Thomas Griesel. © 2020 Carrie Mae Weems

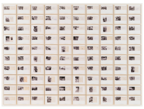


Carrie Mae Weems. *You Become a Scientific Profile*. 1995–96. Chromogenic color print with sand-blasted text on glass, 23 7/8 x 19 15/16 (60.7 x 50.7 cm). The Museum of Modern Art. Gift on behalf of The Friends of Education of The Museum of Modern Art. © 2020 Carrie Mae Weems

From Here I Saw What Happened and I Cried is a series of red-toned photographs bookended by two images of a royal Mangbetu woman witnessing the narrative that unfolds across the works. "When we're looking at these images," Weems said, "we're looking at the ways in which Anglo America—white America—saw itself in relationship to the Black subject." To create these works, the artist gathered different depictions of Black people from historical archives, advertisements, and recognizable twentieth century photographs. The image in *You Become a Scientific Profile* is sourced from a collection of pictures of enslaved people commissioned by Louis Agassiz. Many of the sitters for these photographs are naked or half naked and depicted as anthropological specimens rather than individuals. Weems alludes to this history and the ways such images were used to support racist theories about the inferiority of Black people.

Through her presentation, Weems asks us to question the intentions behind these pictures and their dissemination. She enlarged, cropped, and tinted the images, then placed the prints in circular mattes that suggest the camera's lens, emphasizing the acts of framing and looking. Finally, she overlaid the images with her own texts that expose a long history of systemic injustice. "I wanted to intervene in that by giving a voice to a subject that historically has had no voice."

Walid Raad

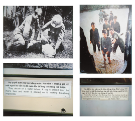


Walid Raad. *My neck is thinner than a hair: Engines*. 1996–2001. One hundred pigmented inkjet prints, each 9 7/16 × 13 3/8" (24 × 34 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2020 The Atlas Group/Walid Raad

Detail from Walid Raad. *My neck is thinner than a hair: Engines*. 1996–2001.

To underscore and simultaneously call into question photography's authority and status as evidence, many artists use existing images from institutions such as libraries, archives, and news outlets. Under the name of The Atlas Group, a fictional foundation and archive, Walid Raad explores questions about the authority and authenticity of officially disseminated information on violence during the Lebanese Civil Wars (1975-1990). *My neck is thinner than a Hair: Engines*, explores some of the thousands of car bomb explosions that occurred in Lebanon during the wars. Rather than sharing facts and figures such as date, location, and number of people killed or injured, Raad presents photographs from newspaper archives of the engines that blasted out of the exploded cars. Though the engines rarely served as evidence in investigations of the violence, Raad notes that politicians often posed next to them to suggest that they were doing everything in their power to solve the crimes. In probing some of the lesser-explored aspects of the wars in Lebanon, Raad highlights our readiness to accept as facts the photographs and official narratives that are presented to us.

Harrell Fletcher


Họ quyết định tra tấn bằng nước. Họ trùm 1 miếng giẻ lên mặt người bị bắt và đổ nước lên để ông ta không thở được.
They decide on a water torture. A rag is placed over the man's face and water is poured on it, making breathing impossible.

Harrell Fletcher. *The American War*. 2005. Two diptychs from a series of 59 pigmented inkjet prints, ranging from 18 × 24" (45.7 × 61 cm), or the reverse, to 10 1/2 × 14" (26.7 × 35.5 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Christine Burgin and William Wegman. © 2020 Harrell Fletcher

In 2005, Harrell Fletcher visited the War Remnants Museum—formerly called the Museum of Chinese and American War Crimes—in Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam, and used a point-and-shoot camera with flash to photograph more than two hundred photographs and wall labels on display. In re-presenting the display about the conflict in Vietnam and its aftermath, Fletcher examines the ways in which history is presented through a specific cultural lens, the use of photography to illustrate the story of war, and the museum's role in constructing and presenting those narratives.

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